



SMALL 'CODING' WONDERS

Scene 1: The National Employability Report 2011, prepared by employability assessment company Aspiring Minds, says only 17.45 per cent of the engineers roped in by the IT sector are employable nationally.

Scene 2: Five students under 17 years of age win Google's Code-In 2011 contest.

These two situations are rather contradictory in nature and show the two extremes of the Indian technology world. But both are true. In a nation like India, where such employability reports grab the headlines, **Gautam Gupta, Abhishek Arora, Gaurav Narula, Aneesh Dogra** and **Shitiz Garg** very well know how to make a mark of their own when it comes to world-class competitions like Google Code-in. These five boys are amongst the ten global grand prize winners of the contest.

The Google Code-In contest for pre-university students (aged 13-17) finds thousands of takers in India and many winners too. The 2011 contest had five out of ten winners from India. The idea of the contest is to encourage young people to participate in open source. For many students, the Google Code-in contest is their first introduction to open source development. For this contest, the company works with several open source organisations, each of whom has experience mentoring students in the *Google Summer of Code* programme, to provide 'bite sized' tasks for participating students to complete.

As many as 542 students from 56 countries participated and completed an impressive 3,054 tasks in the contest. All students who took part in the 2011 edition received a t-shirt and a participation certificate. Those students who successfully completed three or more tasks have received a small monetary prize as well. But the ten grand prize winners will be flown to Google's headquarters in Mountain View, California, in June, along with a parent or

legal guardian for a four-night trip. As mentioned earlier, there are five Indians who will make that trip.

Participating in the Google Code-In contest has not just been a learning experience for these youngsters but also paved the way for a future in technology. Sharing his experience of the contest, Gaurav Narula said, "The whole experience during Google Code-In has been amazing. I got to learn more about open source, programming and about contributing collectively. I came across some outstanding talent during the course of the competition and made great friends. The assistance from the mentors and program managers, round the clock, was a big advantage during the competition, without which it would have been impossible to carry on with the tasks. It was thrilling to see the leader-board fluctuate every now and then during the competition, which kept all of us engaged throughout." Aneesh Dogra shared a similar view. He said, "It was a great experience. The mentors were awesome, I learnt a lot of stuff, I came across a lot of